

# Millennials' purchasing behavior toward fashion clothing brands- influence of brand awareness and brand schematicity

## Introduction

The worldwide fashion apparel market, worth US\$3 trillion, makes up 2% of the global gross domestic product (GDP) and employs 33m textile workers, an increase from 19.7m over the previous 25 years ([Wang et al., 2019](#)). In a similar vein, a report from [Clothing stores \(2019\)](#) also acknowledged that the global revenue in the fashion retailing reached \$1.7 trillion in 2017 and is expected to grow by 2% by 2022. Despite the growth and importance of fashion retailing, only a limited number of studies focus on customers' attitude related to the fashion clothing brands (e.g., [Choi and Choo, 2016](#); [Phau et al., 2015](#); [Vehmas et al., 2018](#)). Therefore, it is essential to understand the brand-related consumers' purchasing behavior more deeply to accelerate the industry performance. The current research has considered millennials, young consumers, born between 1980 and 2000 ([Hartman and McCambridge, 2011](#)). As empirical investigation reveals, globally the millennials represent the largest generational population, and their purchasing power is making them an attractive target for the fashion clothing brand industry ([Moore and Carpenter, 2008](#); [Gerardo, 2018](#)). The segment also represents a significant portion of global fashion retail consumption ([deKerviler and Rodriguez, 2019](#)). Research shows that the millennials are an exceptional cluster who are young, affluent, educated, tech-savvy and inclined to a positive social behavior ([Howe and Strauss, 2009](#)). However, academic literature has so far failed to acknowledge the connection of the significant attributes that affect how the millennials purchase their fashion clothing brands ([Samala and Singh, 2019](#)). Although several studies explore diverse consumers and their behavior in regard to the fashion clothing brands during the year 2000–2019 (see the [Table 1](#)), none of the studies have looked at brand consciousness (BC), brand awareness (BA), brand nationality (BN) and brand schematicity (BS) in one framework to get more insights about the millennials' purchasing behavior toward the fashion clothing brands (MCPBFCB).

### Table 1

Review of selected researches on fashion clothing brand during 2000–2018

**Table 1** Review of selected researches on fashion clothing brand during 2000–2018

| Author(s)                                  | Research context                                                                          |
|--------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <a href="#">Beaudoin et al. (2003)</a>     | Adolescents (male vs female) fashion behavior                                             |
| <a href="#">O'Cass (2004)</a>              | Antecedents and consequences of fashion clothing involvement                              |
| <a href="#">Wang et al. (2004)</a>         | Local and international fashion brand clothing choices and subsequent connection with c   |
| <a href="#">Grant and Stephen (2005)</a>   | Communicating factors influence on "teenage" girls purchasing intentions on fashion cl    |
| <a href="#">O'Cass and Choy (2008)</a>     | Generation Y consumers product involvement for fashion clothing in China                  |
| <a href="#">Goldsmith et al. (2012)</a>    | Materialism, brand engagement and status consumption impact consumer's connection a       |
| <a href="#">O'Cass and Siahtiri (2014)</a> | Fashion clothing buying behavior with the perspective of status consumption and brand st  |
| <a href="#">Su (2016)</a>                  | Examining inter relationship among brand equity dimensions in the fast fashion context    |
| <a href="#">Chang and Fan (2017)</a>       | Determinants of continuous customer-brand relationship through social networking sites    |
| <a href="#">Rahman and Mannan (2018)</a>   | Domestic fashion clothing brands purchase behavior                                        |
| <a href="#">Aagerup and Scharf (2018)</a>  | How fashion model's physical appearance influences the attraction for fashion clothing br |
| <a href="#">Salem and Salem (2018)</a>     | Understanding luxury consumer behavior through a comprehensive model integrating soc      |
| <a href="#">Kautish and Sharma (2018)</a>  | Association among consumer values (instrumental and terminal), fashion consciousness a    |
| <a href="#">Lee et al. (2018)</a>          | Understanding the impact of cultural differences on young consumer's attitudes and purc   |
| <a href="#">Samala and Singh (2019)</a>    | Engagement behavior of millennials for fashion clothing brands                            |

|                                        |                                                                                                                  |
|----------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <a href="#">Jain (2019)</a>            | Conceptualizing and measuring the relationship between luxury value perceptions and pu<br>young luxury consumers |
| <a href="#">Su et al. (2019)</a>       | Perceptions and consumption behavior of US and Chinese millennials towards sustainable                           |
| <a href="#">Miao (2019)</a>            | Understanding different fashion retail store formats of the same brand in what extent and                        |
| <a href="#">Jain (2020)</a>            | Understanding the effect of consumers subjective norm on luxury purchase intentions of                           |
| <a href="#">Jain and Mishra (2020)</a> | Understanding luxury fashion consumption in the perspective of sharing economy                                   |

Source(s): Author's analysis

Authors refer to BC as the consumers' mental orientation to purchasing well-known brand-name products ([Rahman et al., 2020](#); [Mann and Sahni, 2019](#)), whereas BS is a result of the consumer socialization process which provides people with the "skills, knowledge and attitudes" relevant to consumption ([Ward, 1974](#); [Puligadda et al., 2012](#)). Unique experiences with a particular brand influence socialization and may instill consumers with brand-based associations that serve as the cognitive schema and emphasize the value of brands in general ([Rossiter, 1976](#)). According to [Keller \(2003\)](#), BA is the consumers' ability to identify a brand under different conditions in the form of brand recognition and brand recall. Researchers claim that to attract new customers and retain the existing ones, firms need to distinguish themselves from their competitors ([Radder and Huang, 2008](#)). Previous studies also suggested that country image activates concepts and knowledge that form the consumers' interpretation, are that evaluation of products are influencing the assessments of the existing brand ([Ahn et al., 2009](#); [Papadopoulos and Heslop, 2002](#)). The literature also provides evidence that consumers' knowledge of BN or origin may have a significant influence on their judgments of quality, brand attitudes and purchasing behavior in the respective marketplace ([Maheswaran, 1994](#)).

The contemporary researches also suggest that the fashion industry is comprehensive in nature and encompasses the continuous expansion of consumer's understanding regarding the fashion trends, consumers' lifestyle and cultural dimensions ([Peng, 2020](#)). As we see a lot of fashion brands in the marketplace, our purchase decisions follow a thorough evaluation, and thus consumers (e.g., millennials) develop an emotional relationship with brands ([Liu and Chang, 2017](#)). Therefore, we assume that the consumers assess a brand based on the cue of BA, BS, BC and BN; however, there is scant empirical evidence on this topic. In our research context, the millennials who have a high BC of the fashion clothing brands believe that these brands reflect their personality ([Ordun, 2015](#); [Kaur and Anand, 2018](#)). Besides, the millennials' brand preferences have both a direct and indirect effect on the purchasing behavior of their families and peers ([Tang and Chan, 2017](#)). Thus, the primary aim of this research is to investigate MCPBFCB in the spectrum of BA, BS with BC and BN empirically.

This paper starts with a literature review and formulates the research hypotheses along with the development of a conceptual framework, followed by the methods, experimental findings and reporting on the technical and managerial entanglements. Finally, this paper concisely discusses the research limitations and the prospective research direction.

## Literature review and hypotheses development

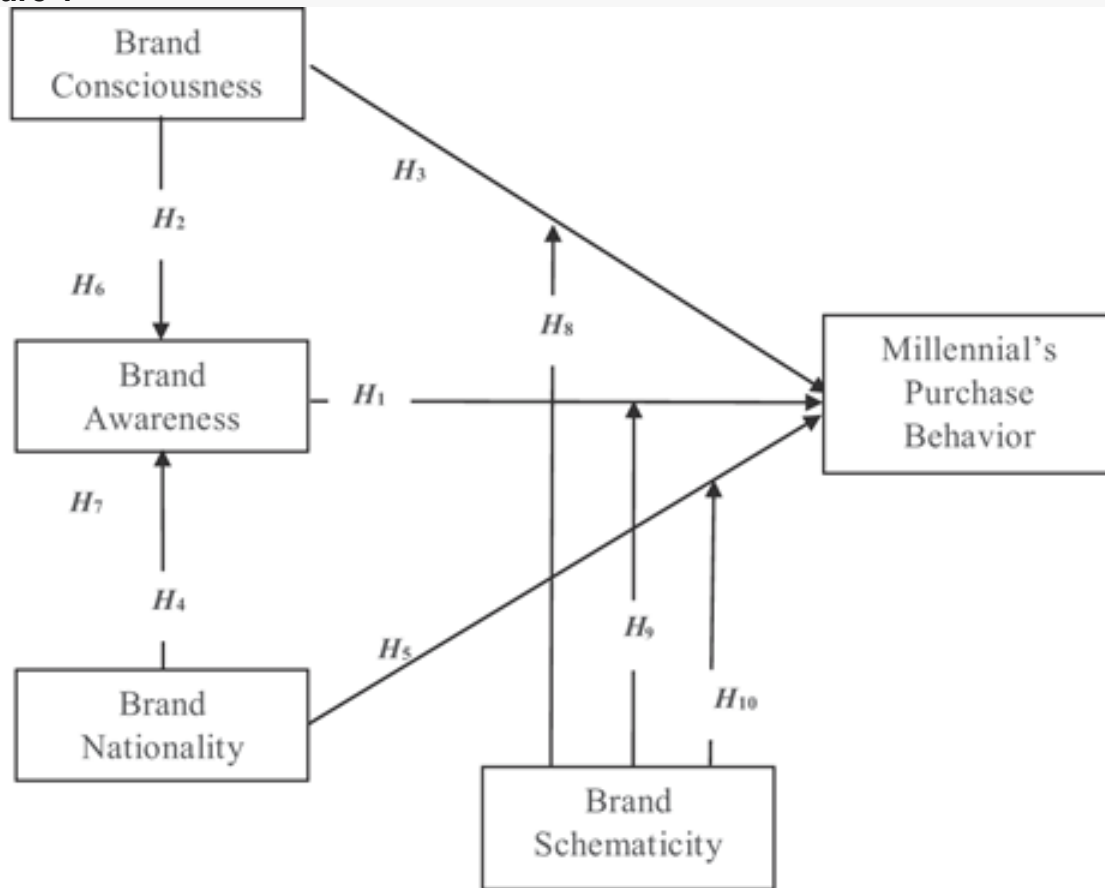
Fashion is an activity whereby an individual expresses personal tastes and interests through clothing. The conceptualization of fashion is considered an objective reflection of behavioral processes through which consumers present their lifestyles ([Vieira, 2009](#)). Fashion clothing is identified as a highly animated product category that communicates the related brand preference ([O'Cass, 2004](#)) and reflects the consumer's self-image ([DaMcNeill and Moore, 2015](#)). Research on fashion has received particular attention in the field of fashion marketing and brand management (e.g., [O'Cass and Siahtiri, 2014](#); [Kautish and Sharma, 2018](#); [Sung and Woo, 2019](#)). Fashion is an innovative industry with dynamic changes that result from technological advancements ([Nash, 2019](#)).

Prior research has extensively studied various dimensions to explain a consumer's behavior toward the fashion clothing brands. The [Table 1](#) presents a summary of the selected studies on the fashion clothing brands. To identify the existing research, we searched the databases of Scopus (Elsevier), Web of Knowledge (Thomson ISI), Business Source Complete (EBSCO host), Emerald and ScienceDirect (Taylor and Francis) with the keyword "fashion clothing brand". As depicted in the [Table 1](#), the marketing scholars mostly emphasized understanding the consumers' fashion buying behaviors for various segments (e.g., millennial, Generation Y). Furthermore, literature streams also reveal that no prior study on the fashion clothing brand highlighted the role of BA and BS together to understand a consumer's purchasing behavior.

On the other hand, BS is a relatively new way to understand the individual differences in processing the brand-associated information that substantially impacts the branding and

marketing efforts ([Puligadda et al., 2012](#)). We take into consideration this phenomenon of individual differences or BS. The primary aim of this paper is to critically analyze the role of BS to understand the purchasing behavior of the millennials. Despite the importance of understanding consumers' brand processing information at the individual level, to the best of our knowledge there has been no empirical evidence on whether BS has a role in predicting MCPBFCB. Therefore, in the present study, we examine the role of BS on the MCPBFCB while considering BA, BC and BN in a single framework as depicted in the [Figure 1](#).

**Figure 1**



**Note(s):** MCPBFCB: Millennial (consumer's) purchase behavior (for fashion clothing brands);  
**BC:** Brand Consciousness, **BN:** Brand Nationality, **BA:** Brand Awareness, **BS:** Brand schematicity

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MCPBFCB embedded with the function of BA, BC, BN and BS

In this study, we also acknowledge the theory of cognitive self-schema. This theory explains an individual's psychology based on the perception of information that humans develop over time and how that built up information drives decision-making ([Halkias, 2015](#)). An individual's positive self-schema plays a moderating role in converting

intentions to actual behavior ([Tikka and Oinas-Kukkonen, 2019](#)) and therefore helps researchers understand the gap between intention and behavior ([David et al., 2009](#)). According to [Samala and Singh \(2019\)](#), the schema knowledge helps to create a particular behavior by highlighting the default choices or the attractive attributes (for example, the decision of buying a specific fashion clothing brand depends on specific attributes that are processed by an individual's psychology). In this study, researchers tried to identify more attributes that the millennials take into consideration when buying the fashion items.

## BA and purchasing behavior

BA is a fundamental driving force for the consumer decision-making. The consumer decision-making for products or services is highly driven by the associated BA, which refers to whether or not consumers can recognize and recall a brand under various circumstances ([Aaker, 1996](#)). Though BA and brand recognition are used interchangeably, brand recognition, along with brand recall, are two pivotal dimensions that illustrate BA ([Keller, 1993, 2009](#)). Brand recognition is based upon an aided recall where consumers can recognize the brands from a given list based on their prior exposure, and brand recall relies on an unaided recall where consumers retrieve brand information from their memory based on industry prompts ([Keller, 1993](#); [Holden, 1993](#); [Radder and Huang, 2008](#); [Edelman, 2010](#)). The first name that comes into a consumer's mind when asked is an example of BA at the highest level ([Laurent et al., 1995](#)). BA is a presence already formed in the mind of the consumers ([Foroudi et al., 2018](#)). BA acts as a primary driver that initiates the building of brand resonance ([Jung Jung et al., 2014](#)), and the demand for a brand is created by the level of a consumer's BA in addition to the role of decision heuristics which significantly influence a consumer's decision-making ([Cheung et al., 2019](#)). The fashion clothing brands are distinctively experiential ([Aaker, 1997](#)), and a consumer's experience is shaped by building confidence and connection, which leads to forming an increased BA ([Huang and Sarigollu, 2012](#); [Lin, 2013](#)). The increased BA creates loyalty and long-term customer relationship opportunities for brands and their consumers ([Khan et al., 2015](#)). BA plays a pivotal role in establishing recognition of the fashion clothing brands among young consumers, positively affecting their brand equity ([Sasmita and Mohd Suki, 2015](#)).

The most recognized model for the consumer purchase decision-making, corroborated by [Engel et al. \(1995\)](#), presents five stages of the consumer decision-making process, where the consumers' purchasing behavior is different from the purchase intention. [Morrison \(1979\)](#) first distinguished between the purchase intention and the purchasing behavior where the purchase intention is the willingness of the consumers to buy a product and the purchasing behavior portrays whether consumers purchase the product they previously intended to buy. So, the purchasing behavior indicates the consumers' actual buying behavior. The consumer purchase intention has been used as a proxy variable to measure the consumer buying behavior ([Tsordia et al., 2018](#)), but the consumer purchase intention does always lead to the actual purchasing behavior ([Zaharia et al., 2016](#); [Tsordia et al., 2018](#)). Much of the more significant part of the



literature on BA from different contexts investigated the association between BA and purchase intentions (e.g. [Liu and Chang, 2017](#); [Martins et al., 2019](#)) in the fashion clothing industry (e.g. [Lee et al., 2018](#); [Jung and Sung, 2008](#); [Kim and Ko, 2012](#)). There is a relatively small body of literature (e.g., [DeGaris et al., 2016](#); [Tsordia et al., 2018](#)) that is concerned with the link between BA and purchasing behavior. [Huang and Sarigöllü \(2014\)](#) empirically exhibited the positive connection between BA and consumers' preference for a brand, followed by the brand market outcomes. Consumers form behaviors directly from a situational or environmental circumstance, and the more consumers experience a product, the more the awareness for that brand grows, which stimulates the consumer purchasing behavior ([Mowen and Minor, 2001](#); [Ahn et al., 2018](#)). For the fashion clothing products, a consumer's degree of involvement in fashion clothing positively influences the consumers' fashion clothing knowledge, or brand knowledge ([O'Cass, 2004](#)), thus increasing BA. The consumers with fashion BA are pioneers with the significant brand knowledge who put a great deal of emphasis on specific fashion clothing brands by searching and collecting the necessary information about them. This enables them to become influential in promoting the fashion clothing brands to their peers ([Dahana et al., 2019](#)). Conversely, only a high-level BA is sufficient to influence a consumer's decision-making process in the low-involvement situations ([Hoyer and Brown, 1990](#)) as in those situations consumers rely on the brand knowledge associated with BA ([Siali, 2019](#)). Therefore, we hypothesize that the higher the BA, the more it will influence MCPBFCB.

*H1.*

BA has a positive influence on the MCPBFCB.

BC and BA

BC is the degree to which a consumer prefers to buy a popular brand's product compared to the other available brands ([Sproles and Kendall, 1986](#)) and also the level of association consumers feel toward the respective product ([Chu et al., 2019](#)). So, the consumers who are brand conscious prefer to buy the branded products. Consumers with a high level of BC perceive that brands portray a symbol of prestige and status ([Liao and Wang, 2009](#); [Khan et al., 2019](#)). Conscious consumers do not want to disengage from the fashion trends as their clothes communicate status and tastes ([Radhakrishnan, 2020](#)). In a recent study, [Kautish et al. \(2020\)](#) exhibited that the consumers' terminal and instrumental values associated with the luxury brands positively influence the consumers' BC particularly for fashion apparels. The fashionable clothing brands represent the self-image enhancement for consumers, motivating them toward luxury consumption to impress others through and establish a high social status ([Giovannini et al., 2015](#)). Moreover, as the proliferation of technology creates easy access to the online fashion retailers, this brings more convenience in shopping for consumers and positively affects their desire to revisit the site ([Kautish and Rai, 2018](#)) and enhances the consumers' BC. Interestingly, the fashion clothing brand shoppers exhibit the highest level of BC ([Sung and Jeon, 2009](#); [Ladhari et al., 2019](#)). BC for fashion clothing is regarded as pivotal for the consumers who want to portray a

prestigious, fashionable lifestyle ([Ismail, 2017](#)). Prior studies (e.g., [Van Grinsven and Das, 2016](#)) examined the logo change effect on consumers' attitudes, and only the consumers with a high BC put significant effort into processing the new information because they valued the changes in the brand attributes. Consumers are motivated to undertake this extensive effort because of their awareness of the brand through prior experience and the importance of the brand in their mind. It is hypothesized in this study that the higher a millennial consumer's BC for the fashion clothing brands, the higher their BA of the fashion clothing products.

*H2.*

BC has a positive influence on BA for the fashion clothing brands.

BC and purchasing behavior

The consumers who are highly brand-conscious seek quality products while making the purchase decisions, particularly in the clothing selection that requires both the quality fit and brand name ([Kaiser, 1998](#); [Kim, 2008](#)). The brand-conscious consumers follow a comfortable pattern that drives them to go for the well-known and expensive choices that represent them with new styles rarely used by others ([Musadik and Azmi, 2019](#)). A great deal of previous research into the BC has highlighted the positive influence of BC on the consumer purchasing behavior (e.g., [Gan et al., 2008](#)). The consumers who are brand-conscious possess a subjective preference toward the reputable brands; thus, their purchasing behavior is different from the consumers with a minimal level of BC. The brand-aware consumers are fashion-conscious and display risk aversion in the purchasing decisions through their brand association ([Liao and Wang, 2009](#)). BC, along with quality consciousness, are identified as the key driving factors in the consumer online shopping behavior ([Jadhav and Khanna, 2016](#)). BC exposes the underlying intention of the consumers to purchase the brands which are analogous to their self-image and identity and exhibit status and prestige ([Giovannini et al., 2015](#)). In a recent study, [Sharda and Bhat \(2018\)](#) articulated that BC is a significant predictor and driver of young consumers' consumption and purchase of the luxury brands. Therefore, BC shapes the consumer purchasing intention which ultimately leads to the actual purchasing behavior. Thus, this study hypothesizes the following:

*H3.*

BC has a positive influence on the MCPBFCB.

BN, BA and purchasing behavior

The proliferation of the Internet and globalization has brought the world of information to our finger tips, which enables consumers to be updated about the latest fashion trends of different countries and celebrities. BN is also known as nation branding, which refers to the distinctive blends of elements with diversified dimensions that provide a nation differentiation and association from a cultural perspective for its target audiences



([Dinnie, 2015](#)). Brands put extensive effort into crafting and positioning a brand's identity in the mind of consumers by familiarizing and inspiring consumers nationally and internationally ([Mitterfellner, 2019](#)). The nation branding exposes a considerable set of connotations about a nation that is activated in a consumer's mind through what he/she experiences, listens to and remembers ([Eusébio and Vieira, 2013](#)). The brand of a nation is reflected through its image, values and identity and the communication of those factors to the external world so that the consumers of other nations build positive perceptions toward that particular nation ([Sataoen, 2019](#)). The country of origin, destination branding, country-product image and country identity all underpin the nation branding concept ([Fetscherin, 2010](#)). We assume that the country-product image is pertinent in our study context. The country image is an effective evaluation of the existing products along with an assessment of the new products from that country ([Tse and Gorn, 1993](#)), as well as an acceptance of the foreign products ([Yang et al., 2018](#)). The brands built upon the country image affect the consumer product evaluations by evoking positive or negative feelings followed by positive or negative ratings which indeed lead to favorable or unfavorable product preferences ([Semaan et al., 2019](#)). Consumers have the perception that the products from the developed countries (e.g., USA, France, Australia and UK) are much better produced and manufactured ([Lee et al., 2013](#)). The brands that are associated with a perceived high-quality country image are already positioned and recognized in the mind of consumers, which positively influences the consumer risk-value perceptions and the willingness to experience the product ([Sharma, 2011](#)). Because of this BA and BN, consumers will favorably evaluate the new products and brand line extensions from the same country. Therefore, we hypothesize that the higher the BN of the fashion clothing brand, the higher the BA of their fashion products.

#### *H4.*

BN has a positive influence on BA of the fashion clothing brands.

BN brings a positive influence on the consumer purchasing decisions as consumers believe that a product's or service's origin delivers quality. Certain consumers have firm affinity toward the foreign products, and this buying intention has become a priority for the global marketers ([Oberecker and Diamantopoulos, 2011](#)). These same marketers experience a high corporate competition as they try to achieve global market expansion ([Nasution and Rossanty, 2018](#)). Early examples of research on the nation branding (e.g., [Verlegh et al., 2005](#); [Nes, 2018](#)) emphasized that the practitioners should assess the consumer purchasing behavior with the product-country match information, which will lead to formulating their product branding strategy. The nation branding with a favorable product-country image has an immediate effect on consumer beliefs and directly influences their purchasing behaviors ([Fan, 2006](#); [Yoon and Lee, 2019](#)). Nation branding is an indispensable attribute, unlike price–quality, that directly affects the consumer purchasing behavior by simplifying the product evaluations and decision-making process ([Karimov and El-Murad, 2019](#)). The nation branding acts as an extrinsic cue for the consumer product evaluation and the subsequent purchasing behaviors ([Coffey and Kabadayi, 2019](#)). Thereby, we hypothesize the following:

H5.

BN has a positive influence on MCPBFCB.

### Mediating role of BA

We theorize that BA exerts a mediated (indirect) influence on the consumer purchasing behavior involving BC and BN. At the time of purchase, the first thing that comes into a consumer's mind is the brand title or name, which shows the BA and brand recognition ([Shabbir et al., 2010, 2017](#)). Despite the direct effect of BC and BN on the consumer purchasing behavior, we expect BA to transmit the impact of BC and the BN indirectly on the consumer purchasing behavior. Previous research (e.g., [ShahinSharifi, 2014](#)) examined the mediating role of BA between the consumers' emotional dimensions and purchase intentions for the high-involvement products. [Garg et al. \(2016\)](#) exhibited the significant mediating role of BA between the marketing-mix elements and the consumers' satisfaction in the context of the consumer durable goods sector. The mediating role of BA was also examined in another study ([Khan et al., 2016](#)) to understand the effectiveness of brand advertisement on brand commitment in the female apparel industry. [Asadollahi et al. \(2018\)](#) investigated the relationship between the sports consumers' satisfaction and the expected product-service quality with post-purchasing behavior and the mediating role of BA. In a recent study, [Hafez \(2018\)](#) articulated the mediating position of BA between corporate social responsibility and brand equity. However, the role of BA as a mediator between BC and purchasing behavior followed by BN and purchasing behavior is rarely explored in the context of fashion clothing brands. Therefore, this study postulates the following hypotheses for further empirical assessment:

H6.

BA mediates the relationship between BC and the MCPBFCB.

H7.

BA mediates the relationship between BN and the MCPBFCB.

### BS

The role of branding has a significant impact on understanding consumer behaviors. The consumer–brand relationship has been extensively researched in the field of marketing (e.g., [Aaker and Keller, 1990](#); [Keller, 1993](#); [Hayes et al., 2019](#)), with a finding that some consumers respond in the same manner to a firm's branding activities, whereas other consumers are either brand-schematic or brand-aschematic ([Puligadda et al., 2012](#)). BS is an individual characteristic that says that the brand-schematic consumers process information for any product in reference to its available brand information, whereas the brand-aschematic consumers ([Puligadda et al., 2012](#)) consider other details instead of brand information. Commercially positioned brands get

prioritized by the brand-schematic consumers, and across all product categories this BS can be applied ([Carsana and Jolibert, 2017](#)). The brand-schematic consumers organize, interpret and retrieve consumption-related information at the level of the brand node ([Keller, 1998](#); [Kim et al., 2019](#)). Moreover, the brand-schematic consumers value the brand which is essential to them.

Brand information is perceived diagnostically by the brand-schematic consumers, and they adopt the schema-related dimensions to evaluate and criticize the brand-related news ([Meyers-Levy and Tybout, 1989](#); [Puligadda et al., 2012](#)). Prior research (e.g., [Jeon and Lee, 2016](#)) examined the relationship between the aesthetic brands and the brand accessories with the moderating role of BS. [Carsana and Jolibert \(2017\)](#) exhibited the moderating role BS in purchasing situations have on the product cues perceived necessary by the consumers. In a recent study [Carsana and Jolibert \(2018\)](#) explored the influence of BS on the brand authenticity in respect to the private-level brands. They found that the brand-schematic consumers perceive the brand authenticity dimensions that are favorable, and the BS also increases the consumer willingness to pay for the private-level brands. In our research about the fashion clothing brands, consumers process extensive information in all the brand-associated settings: BN, BC, BA and subsequently MCPBFCB. Consumers who are receptive deliberately receive, store, interpret and retrieve brand information for the decision-making purposes. Therefore, the individual differences in brand information reflect the impact of the branding efforts, purchasing behavior and overall consumer behaviors. We posit that BS has a moderating role in our research context and hypothesize the following:

*H8.*

The higher the consumers' BS, the higher the positive effect of BC on the MCPBFCB.

*H9.*

The higher the consumers' BS, the higher the positive effect of BA on the MCPBFCB.

*H10.*

The higher the consumers' BS, the higher the positive effect of BN on the MCPBFCB.

Therefore, based on the above discussion, the following conceptual model ([Figure 1](#)) for this empirical study explains the relationship between fashion clothing BA and MCPBFCB by considering BC and BN, along with investigating the role of BS as a moderator between MCPBFCB.

## Research methods

The study used the structural equation modeling (SEM) method for analysing the proposed conceptual model as it was more flexible concerning the data requirements, model complexity and relationship specifications. To perform the statistical analysis, the

software packages AMOS 20 and SPSS 20 were employed. Before executing the test of hypotheses, the data for assessing the connected constructs, collected through the survey, were verified to check for reliability and validity. The study adopted the Cronbach's  $\alpha$  and the confirmatory factor analysis (CFA) to assess the reliability and the robustness of the instrument, respectively. Besides, the research also used the metrics such as composite reliability (CR), the average variance extracted (AVE) and loadings to test the instrument's reliability and validity ([Hair et al., 2010](#)).

## Data collection and sample profile

The study applied self-administered questionnaires by using the shopping mall and university campus intercept procedures, similar to [Hossain et al. \(2017\)](#). The current research adopted a convenient sampling process to generate a substantial amount of respondents to conduct the current research. This study used the millennial consumers in Bangladesh born between the years 1980 and 2000, aged 19–39 years at the time of the data collection period. The study collected the data over a 14-week period including both the weekdays and the weekends, measuring the millennial consumer's purchase behavior toward the fashion clothing brand in the shopping-related environment and the university campus environment that allowed the population of interest to relate to what the research intends to investigate by this empirical study ([Wang et al., 2005](#); [Sweetin et al., 2013](#)). Hence, during the data collection period, the research applied the snowball sampling process to use the subjects to identify another issue among their acquaintances, aged 19–39. Well-trained research assistants were used to do the data collection. The survey instrument was designed to take the respondents not more than 15 min to complete. The survey started with the screening questions to verify that the respondents met the criteria of the survey (i.e., year born). Afterward, the constructs were included to measure the possible predictors of MCPBFCB – namely, BC, BA, BN and BS. The survey also concluded with the demographic questions. Each of the constructs was measured using a five-point Likert scale, with 5 being strongly agree and 1 being strongly disagree. The detail of the demographic characteristics is given in the [Table 2](#).

**Table 2**

Demographic characteristics of the respondents ( $n = 266$ )

| Characteristics            | Total | Percentage |
|----------------------------|-------|------------|
| <i>Gender</i>              |       |            |
| Male                       | 155   | 58%        |
| Female                     | 111   | 42%        |
| <i>Age (Mean)</i>          |       |            |
| Male                       | 23.17 |            |
| Female                     | 22.10 |            |
| <i>Permanent residence</i> |       |            |
| Dhaka                      | 70    | 26%        |
| Chittagong                 | 60    | 23%        |

| Characteristics                                       | Total | Percentage |
|-------------------------------------------------------|-------|------------|
| Rajshahi                                              | 23    | 9%         |
| Mymensingh                                            | 15    | 7%         |
| Barisal                                               | 18    | 6%         |
| Khulna                                                | 20    | 7%         |
| Sylhet                                                | 50    | 18%        |
| Rangpur                                               | 10    | 4%         |
| <i>Education</i>                                      |       |            |
| College student                                       | 20    | 8%         |
| Bachelor's student                                    | 186   | 70%        |
| First year master's student                           | 60    | 22%        |
| <i>Money spent on clothing a month (IUSD = 83BDT)</i> |       |            |
| \$20 or less                                          | 59    | 22%        |
| \$21-\$50                                             | 177   | 67%        |
| \$50 and above                                        | 30    | 11%        |

### Construct operationalization and data analysis method

The survey instruments were constructed based on some of the validated scales used in previous studies ( [Appendix 1. Table A1](#)). The constructs were measured using multi-item scales. To investigate MCPBFCB, the study adapted the existing scales: BC (6-items), adapted from [Giovannini et al. \(2015\)](#); BN (6-items), adapted from [MohdYasin et al. \(2007\)](#); MCPBFCB (3-items), adapted from [Caruana \(2002\)](#); BA (4-items), adapted from [Yoo and Donthu \(2001\)](#) and BS (6-items), adapted from [Zarantonello and Pauwels-Delassus \(2015\)](#).

**Table A1**

Measurement scales

### Variables

#### BC

- I pay attention to the brand names of the clothes I buy
- Brand names tell me something about the quality of the clothing
- Brand names tell me something about how "cool" an item of clothing is
- Sometimes I am willing to pay more money for clothing because of its brand name
- Brand name clothes that cost a lot of money are good quality
- I pay attention to the brand names of most of the products I buy

#### BN

- The country from which the fashion clothing brand originates is a country that is innovative in manufacturing
- The country from which the fashion clothing brand originates is a country that has high level of technological advance
- The country from which the fashion clothing brand originates is a country that is good in designing
- The country from which the fashion clothing brand originates is a country that is creative in its workmanship
- The country from which the fashion clothing brand originates is a country that is prestigious
- The fashion clothing brand originates from a country that has an image of advanced country

| Variables                                                                                               |
|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <i>MCPBFCB</i>                                                                                          |
| I have purchased more this fashion brand clothing over the last several years than other fashion brands |
| I consider this fashion clothing brand as my primary fashion brand                                      |
| This fashion clothing brand has been my primary fashion brand for the past few years                    |
| <i>BA</i>                                                                                               |
| I can recognize my fashion clothing brand among other competing brands                                  |
| I am aware of my fashion clothing brand                                                                 |
| Some characteristics of my fashion clothing brand come to my mind quickly                               |
| I can quickly recall the symbol or logo of my fashion clothing brand                                    |
| <i>BS</i>                                                                                               |
| Fashion clothing brand attributes are more important than fashion brand names in my buying decisions    |
| When I go shopping for fashion clothing, I am always scanning the environment for fashion brand names   |
| Fashion brands are not at all important to me                                                           |
| I like to surround myself with recognizable fashion clothing brand names at home                        |
| The fashion brand name is the least important information to me when I am considering a product         |
| I keep well-informed of the fashion clothing brands people around me are using                          |

**Note(s):** All the scale items are modified to fit the domain of fashion clothing brand)

### Common method variance

Common method bias, in the context of SEM-oriented research, is brought about by the estimation technique utilized in the examination and not by the system of circumstances and results in the model being considered. For example, the rules at the start of an instrument may impact the appropriate responses given by various subjects (respondents) in a similar general course, making the markers share a specific measure of common variation. The current research has spent considerable time measuring the common method variance effect in the design of studies and statistically. In the context of research design, researchers improve scale items by eliminating ambiguity, reducing social desirability bias, word selection and the use of positive and negative elements. In this aspect, the current study carefully constructs the items by defining the unfamiliar terms, avoiding vague concepts and clarifying the concepts to the respondents during the survey, making the instrument simple, specific and concise and avoiding double-barreled questions. Also, we applied the Harman's single-factor test by using the exploratory factor analysis procedure for all the datasets. The results revealed that the single-factor solution accounted for only 33.05% of the total variance. Hence, common method variance was not a concern in this study as the common method bias is insignificant. Therefore, the study can proceed to the CFA and hypothesis testing.

## Research findings

CFA and assessment of validity and reliability



CFA was performed on five constructs, including BC, BN, MCPBFCB, BA and BS. We used the maximum likelihood estimation in AMOS in the data analysis prior to incorporating the structural relationship ([Jöreskog and Sörbom, 1993](#)). The current research assessed the measurement model through the criteria of unidimensionality, reliability, validity and normality. Data achieve unidimensionality when all the items under each construct have acceptable factor loadings that are greater than 0.5 ([Hair et al., 2006](#)). Reliability is the degree to which the things are dependably estimating the expected latent construct. The current study examines the reliability with the criterion of the Cronbach's alpha value under the paradigm of more than or equal to 0.7 ([Nunnally and Bernstein, 1994](#)). The outcomes of the unidimensionality and dependability investigation for all the constructs are displayed in the [Table 3](#).

**Table 3**

Results of unidimensionality, reliability, convergent validity and discriminant analysis

| First-order construct | Item             | Factor loading (> 0.5) | Cronbach's alpha (> 0.7) | CR (> 0.7) | AVE (> 0.5) |         |    |    |  |
|-----------------------|------------------|------------------------|--------------------------|------------|-------------|---------|----|----|--|
| BC                    | BC1              | 0.788                  | 0.900                    | 0.918      | 0.6533      |         |    |    |  |
|                       | BC2              | 0.798                  |                          |            |             |         |    |    |  |
|                       | BC3              | 0.807                  |                          |            |             |         |    |    |  |
|                       | BC4              | 0.739                  |                          |            |             |         |    |    |  |
|                       | BC5              | 0.832                  |                          |            |             |         |    |    |  |
|                       | BC6              | 0.879                  |                          |            |             |         |    |    |  |
| BN                    | BN1              | 0.728                  | 0.891                    | 0.902      | 0.602       |         |    |    |  |
|                       | BN2              | 0.785                  |                          |            |             |         |    |    |  |
|                       | BN3              | 0.705                  |                          |            |             |         |    |    |  |
|                       | BN4              | 0.831                  |                          |            |             |         |    |    |  |
|                       | BN5              | 0.832                  |                          |            |             |         |    |    |  |
|                       | BN6              | 0.789                  |                          |            |             |         |    |    |  |
| MCPBFCB               | MCPBFCB1         | 0.633                  | 0.843                    | 0.862      | 0.682       |         |    |    |  |
|                       | MCPBFCB2         | 0.902                  |                          |            |             |         |    |    |  |
|                       | MCPBFCB3         | 0.912                  |                          |            |             |         |    |    |  |
| BA                    | BA1              | 0.845                  | 0.901                    | 0.917      | 0.685       |         |    |    |  |
|                       | BA2              | 0.843                  |                          |            |             |         |    |    |  |
|                       | BA3              | 0.868                  |                          |            |             |         |    |    |  |
|                       | BA4              | 0.873                  |                          |            |             |         |    |    |  |
| BS                    | BS1              | 0.787                  | 0.882                    | 0.904      | 0.614       |         |    |    |  |
|                       | BS2              | 0.818                  |                          |            |             |         |    |    |  |
|                       | BS3              | 0.857                  |                          |            |             |         |    |    |  |
|                       | BS4              | 0.639                  |                          |            |             |         |    |    |  |
|                       | BS5              | 0.732                  |                          |            |             |         |    |    |  |
|                       | BS6              | 0.849                  |                          |            |             |         |    |    |  |
|                       | Latent construct | MSV                    | ASV                      | BC         | BN          | MCPBFCB | BA | BS |  |
|                       | BC               | 0.328                  | 0.227                    | 0.808      |             |         |    |    |  |
|                       | BN               | 0.350                  | 0.175                    | 0.561*     | 0.775       |         |    |    |  |

| Latent construct | MSV   | ASV   | BC     | BN     | MCPBFCB | BA     | BS    |
|------------------|-------|-------|--------|--------|---------|--------|-------|
| MCPBFCB          | 0.278 | 0.166 | 0.573* | 0.592  | 0.825   |        |       |
| BA               | 0.278 | 0.127 | 0.491* | 0.539* | 0.528*  | 0.827  |       |
| BS               | 0.253 | 0.213 | 0.516* | 0.503* | 0.471*  | 0.503* | 0.783 |

**Note(s):** Convergent validity CR > AVE and AVE > 0.50; discriminant validity MSV < AVE; ASV < AVE \* significant at the 0.05 level

The study also tested the data to fit with the validity criteria which assess the ability of a construct to measure what it is supposed to measure. In this study, convergent and discriminant validities were examined for each construct. For testing the convergent validity, the composite reliability (CR) value must be more than or equal to 0.7 and the average variance extracted (AVE) value must be more significant than or alike 0.5 ([Hair et al., 2010](#)). The result from the data revealed that all the constructs had fulfilled these two requirements (See the [Table 3](#)). In addition, the study tested discriminant validity by the square root of AVE for each construct, which should be higher than the correlation coefficients among the constructs ([Hair et al., 2010](#)). The statistical results also passed this threshold.

The results from the CFA analysis suggested that the chi-square value ( $\chi^2$ ) at 235 degrees of freedom is 365.1 which is less than or equal to 5.0 ( $365/235 = 1.55$ ;  $p < 0.016$ ) suggesting a satisfactory model fit. In addition, the study also tested other assessment measures to examine the model fit indexes such as the goodness-of-fit index (GFI) (0.911), adjusted goodness-of-fit index (AGFI) (0.890), the comparative fit index (CFI) (0.921), the Tucker–Lewis index (TLI) (0.913) and the root-mean-square error of approximation (RMSEA) (0.047). Thus, the result from the CFA analysis concluded that the data fit well on the proposed model. The study then examined the psychometric properties of the measurement model through validity and reliability tests. The results from the analysis revealed that all the standardized factor loadings of the items for the underlying constructs are all significant at the 0.001 level and entirely suggest evidence of convergent validity ([Bagozzi et al., 1991](#)). In addition, the [Table 3](#) also highlights the result of the reliability and validity tests for evaluating the measurement model. That is, each item strikes the component of the intended construct significantly (see the [Table 3](#)). The current study calculates construct reliability (CR), AVE, Cronbach alpha, maximum shared variance (MSV) and average shared variance (ASV) ([Hair et al., 2010](#)). The study shows that the value of CR and the Cronbach alpha of each construct meet the requirement as well as the convergent validity. In this study, the researchers performed the MSV and ASV to support whether the theoretical construct of the measurement model is well defined or not. According to the [Fornell and Larcker \(1981\)](#) index, higher values of AVE compared to the shared variance amongst the square of correlations in terms of pairs of constructs validate the discriminant validity. The result of the MSV and ASV should be lower than 0.50 to indicate a valid model. By inspecting both the ASV and MSV, the result suggests that the measurement model is indeed valid. As highlighted in the [Table 3](#), the AVE for each construct is greater than all the related correlations, thus indicating discriminant validity ([Fornell and Larcker, 1981](#)).

## Structural model

After confirming the validity and reliability of the data, the study tested the SEM to measure the hypothesized relations of BA, BC, BN and millennials' BC toward MCPBFCB. The SEM analysis is similar to the study of [Rahman et al. \(2019, 2018\)](#). The model was checked for the fitness, and the results were satisfactory in respect to  $\chi^2/df = 2.47$  ( $\chi^2 = 467.61$ ,  $df = 189$ ),  $p < 0.05$ ; GFI = 0.925, AGFI = 0.905, CFI = 0.924, TLI = 0.914, and RMSEA = 0.051. The fit indices all meet the suggested statistic cut-off values.

## Hypotheses testing

Each hypothesized relationship was examined based on the path significance test. The [H3](#) proposed that the BC has a positive influence on the MCPBFCB. The results showed that BA significantly influence the MCPBFCB ( $\beta = 0.28$ ,  $t = 5.37$ ,  $p < 0.001$ ). Thus, the [H3](#) was supported. Additionally, the [H5](#) predicted that BN has a positive influence on MCPBFCB. The results from the SEM found that a significant relationship exists between these two variables ( $\beta = 0.35$ ,  $t = 5.07$ ,  $p < 0.001$ ). Therefore, the research supports the [H3](#) and [H5](#).

To further test the mediating effect of BA between the relationships of BC and MCPBFCB, as well as between BN and MCPBFCB, the study applied [Baron and Kenny \(1986\)](#) recommended procedure. A significant amount of research has applied the mediation testing suggested by Baron and Kenny ([Ho et al., 2012](#); [Mallinckrodt et al., 2006](#)). In addition, in the context of fashion marketing research, the application of a mediation analysis using the logic suggested by [Baron and Kenny \(1986\)](#) has also been observed in the literature ([Gautam and Sharma, 2017](#); [Afonso Vieira, 2009](#)). A variable may function as a mediator when it meets all the following three conditions:

1. The independent variables (BC and BN) significantly influence the mediating variable (BA) (path a);
2. The mediating variable significantly affects the dependent variable (path b); (BA toward MCPBFCB)

and

- (3) When paths a and b are controlled by the study, a previously significant relation between the independent variables and the dependent variable is no longer meaningful.

In that regard, we hypothesized that BC and BN would have a positive influence on BA among MCPBFCB ([H2](#); [H4](#)). The results show that both the variables have a significant influence on BA. Thus, the [H2](#) ( $\beta = 0.21$ ,  $t = 5.73$ ,  $p < 0.001$ ) and [H4](#) ( $\beta = 0.16$ ,  $t = 5.27$ ,  $p < 0.001$ ) are supported. The [H1](#) states BA has a positive influence on MCPBFCB. A significant positive effect was found from the data analysis

that justifies supporting the [H1](#) ( $\beta = 0.19$ ,  $t = 5.43$ ,  $p < 0.001$ ). Hence, the [H1](#) is supported.

Following Baron and Kenny recommendation to test the indirect effect of BA between the relationship of BC and BN, the direct impact of each relationship was examined and proved significant. After introducing the mediator variable (i.e., BA), the paths became insignificant, indicating that both the variables (i.e., BC and BN) are fully mediated by the BA ( $R^2 = 0.591$ ). Afterward, we tested separately the idea that the BA demonstrated the stronger mediating effect on BC and MCPBFCB ( $R^2 = 0.471$ ) than on the relationship between BN and MCPBFCB ( $R^2 = 0.291$ ). Based on the above findings, the current research supported the [H6](#) and [H7](#).

The [Table 4](#) summarizes the results for the moderating role of BS. We also found significant interaction effects of the moderators among the three relationships (see [Figure 1](#)). The low and high values of BC, BN, BA and moderator variable BS represent values that are one standard deviation below and above the mean, respectively. For the dataset of the millennial consumers' purchase behavior for the fashion clothing brands (MCPBFCB), the interaction between BC and BS was significant ( $\beta = 0.267$ ,  $p < 0.01$ ). The simple slope analysis revealed that BC is positively related to MCPBFCB when the millennials perceived a high level of BS. Thus, this research accepted the [H8](#), which shows that the higher the consumer BS, the higher the positive effect of BC on MCPBFCB. To test the interaction hypotheses of the [H9](#), we first standardized the independent variables (BS, BA and MCPBFCB) and then created the product variables. In this process, the results from the SEM analysis revealed that the interactions between BS and BA were significant. Thus, the higher the consumer BS, the higher the positive effect of BA on MCPBFCB, as shown in the [Table 4](#). Therefore, the current research supports the [H9](#). Also, the simple slope analysis revealed that BN was positively related to MCPBFCB when BS was positive and on a high level ( $\beta = 0.188$ ,  $p < 0.01$ ). These results support the [H10](#). Besides, the results also reveal that the model fit for each interaction effect analysis is in the threshold level for the final moderated model.

**Table 4**

Results of moderation analysis

| Predictors          | Estimate    | Standard error | Critical ratio | Significant level |
|---------------------|-------------|----------------|----------------|-------------------|
| <b>BC</b>           |             |                |                |                   |
| MCPBFCB < --- BC    | 0.339       | 0.062          | 5.097          | 0.000             |
| MCPBFCB < --- BS    | 0.134       | 0.046          | 2.197          | 0.000             |
| MCPBFCB < --- BC*BS | 0.267       | 0.052          | 4.192          | 0.000             |
| $\chi^2/DF = 1.76$  | CFI = 0.989 | GFI = 0.964    | RMSEA = 0.013  |                   |
| <b>BA</b>           |             |                |                |                   |
| MCPBFCB < --- BA    | 0.498       | 0.070          | 6.107          | 0.000             |
| MCPBFCB < --- BS    | 0.274       | 0.065          | 3.535          | 0.000             |
| MCPBFCB < --- BA*BS | 0.238       | 0.051          | 5.238          | 0.000             |

|                     |                 |                       |                       |                          |
|---------------------|-----------------|-----------------------|-----------------------|--------------------------|
| $\chi^2/DF = 1.33$  | CFI = 0.991     | GFI = 0.990           | RMSEA = 0.015         |                          |
| <b>BN</b>           | <b>Estimate</b> | <b>Standard error</b> | <b>Critical Ratio</b> | <b>Significant Level</b> |
| MCPBFCB < --- BN    | 0.388           | 0.059                 | 6.075                 | 0.000                    |
| MCPBFCB < --- BS    | 0.134           | 0.046                 | 3.345                 | 0.000                    |
| MCPBFCB < --- BN*BS | 0.188           | 0.032                 | 5.438                 | 0.000                    |
| $\chi^2/DF = 1.46$  | CFI = 0.979     | GFI = 0.954           | RMSEA = 0.012         |                          |

**Note(s):** MCPBFCB: millennial consumers' purchase behavior for fashion clothing brands; BC: brand consciousness, BN: brand nationality, BA: brand awareness, BS: brand schematicity

The major objective of the current research was to examine the theoretical model proposed by the study and prove the empirical relationships among the constructs (see the [Figure 1](#)). The SEM result revealed that the proposed conceptual model predicts the millennials' purchasing behavior in light of BC, BN and BA, with BS in support. The following section explains the overall findings of the research based on the proposed hypotheses.

## Discussions

The millennials' purchasing behavior has been studied extensively in recent years for various product or service segments: cosmetics (e.g., [Ishak et al., 2019](#); [Haque et al., 2018](#)), apparel (e.g., [Pasricha et al., 2020](#); [Stewart and Carey, 2020](#)), technology ([Calvo-Porrall et al., 2019](#); [Purani et al., 2019](#)), tourism ([Kim and Park, 2020](#); [Liu et al., 2019](#)) and so on. Different generations portray distinctive and dynamic behavioral dimensions, so the millennials is an interesting group to study because of the millennials' unique characteristics and high BA ([Moreno et al., 2017](#)). The existing body of research has demonstrated to a great extent the consumers' behavior in association with BA ([Chakraborty, 2019](#)), BC ([Khan et al., 2019](#)) and BN ([Echeverri et al., 2019](#)). Analyzing MCPBFCB can help the marketers and the designers to understand consumers' needs and desires in regard to the fashion clothing brands thereby helping them to focus on taking steps to reform their brand-related marketing strategy.

In this study, we tested whether BC, BN and BA foster MCPBFCB. In addition, the current research also investigates the direct and indirect links between the millennial consumers' concern of BC and BN, as well as the mediating role of BA. Drawing on previous research, the data from these findings support the effect of BA and show how it mediates the relationship. In particular, BA reconciles the path from BC and BN to MCPBFCB.

This SEM result also indicates that MCPBFCB is not just a matter of quality, promotion, pricing and distribution. In fact, and to an even greater extent, it shows the importance of BC and BN and the overall BA among millennials. Based on the analytical results, BA actively mediates BC and MCPBFCB, in addition to the BN and MCPBFCB relationship. This relationship supports previous research which argued that consumers are

conscious of brands before they make a repeat purchase ([Wood, 2004](#); [Palumbo and Herbig, 2000](#)). This finding also indicates that BA in the context of fashion clothing brands is an influencing factor between BC and millennial consumers for fashion clothing brands within the competitive fashion clothing market of Bangladesh. Besides, we investigated the moderator role of BS in the relationship between BC and MCPBFCB, BN and MCPBFCB and BA and MCPBFCB. We found that all of the MCPBFCB variables are significantly influenced by BS. For individuals with a low propensity to BS, BC, BA, and BN had no effect on MCPBFCB. The interaction effect observed was significant even after controlling for relevant demographics, namely gender.

## Theoretical implications

Considering that marketing and consumers' buying behavior are firmly related, the influencing variable of one on the other in the actual buying behavior of consumers is intriguing. This investigation contributes to understanding the behavior of millennials, which is a significant profitable segment for the fashion retailers. The theory of cognitive schema portrayed in this research showed how knowledge about the particular fashion brand is formed and conceptualized in the target customer's mind when deciding to buy. The application of this theory was limited in most of the prior research. However, the implication of it is significant because of how consumers process information and decide to buy something for themselves. The inner structure of schema stays stable across overdesigned spaces, and that enables the analysts to regard schematic properties as vital parts of the equivalent hypothetical framework that can be adequately connected in various settings and related to different ideas ([Halkias, 2015](#)). The results of the study empirically contribute to the existing literature of millennial purchasing behavior through a cognitive self-schema theory ([Samala and Singh, 2019](#); [Segal, 1988](#)). The uniqueness of the study is examining the concepts of BA, BS, BC and BN under the cognitive schema theory paradigm. Besides, this research is one of the first efforts in the context of Bangladesh's millennial consumers to identify the significant antecedents such as BA and BS that change the relationship between BC, BN and MCPBFCB. Previous research has emphasized almost exclusively the role of experience, perceptual maps, consumer status, brand engagement, brand involvement and brand knowledge on millennial purchasing behavior ([Ordun, 2015](#); [Samala and Singh, 2019](#)). Our findings contribute to the literature on brand management and consumer research by demonstrating that MCPBFCB is significantly influenced by BC and BN, with the presence of BA as mediation and the role of BS as a significant moderator among all the direct relationships.

## Managerial implications

From the managerial point of view, this research explains MCPBFCB embedded with the function of BA, BC, BN and BS. The study confirms that the fashion clothing brand marketers should utilize potential opportunities of accessible social media technology such as Facebook and Twitter to create BA and brand preference among this group and



establish future preferences and possibly brand loyalty toward their fashion clothing brand. In order to capture different consumer segments, [Kautish and Sharma \(2018\)](#) argue that the most effective and convincing promotion strategy may be required by the online fashion clothing brands for creating a judicious mix in the minds of the target consumers.

In addition, marketers should apply both online and offline advertising in developing BA of fashion clothing brands as millennials are a niche market segment but extremely attractive for retailers. Therefore, the current research also suggests that for influencing their purchasing behavior, the marketers need to understand trends that may assist them in clarifying their sensitivity and awareness toward local and international fashion clothing brands. Millennials are growing up in an environment where technology provides a platform for personalization and immediate gratification in all aspects of their life. Therefore, the marketers should continuously update their online content and train their managers to effectively use social network sites to respond immediately to the millennial demands of fashion clothing brands. The results from this research also support the idea that millennials are brand-conscious and thus have significant brand loyalty toward fashion clothing brands. The results indicated that the millennials who have a high level of BC are more concerned about BA information to inform their purchasing behavior.

Considering the substantial branding efforts of fashion clothing brand outlets, our research could be invaluable to the practitioners. For example, as the findings show, the role of BS is high among the relationships. Thus, millennial shoppers are progressively distracted with brand data and subsequently can be reached by online and offline advertising that publicizes the fashion clothing brands rather than their attributes. In contrast, the brand-aschematic purchasers likely are persuaded more by product attribute-oriented information ([Joshi and Hanssens, 2010](#)). Moreover, BS can speed up information processing and influence judgment regarding BC, BA and BN. This provides efficiently an accessible measure of the millennials' purchasing behavior because it enables the consumer to make the best choice among the other fashion clothing brand alternatives. The results of this study show that information is vital to millennials when choosing the right fashion clothing brand. The result from this present research provides a new perspective that addresses millennial customers' interaction not only through physical experience but also through virtual technology during their offline and online shopping experience ([Kautish and Sharma, 2019](#)). The fashion clothing brand managers can focus on brand-schematic cues by providing consumers with various information such as leaflets that explain a commercial brand's origin and value of the fashion clothing brand. Therefore, consumers should also be provided with technology-mediated tools which they could scan for data about different rational cues before picking their fashion brand. A brand-schematic buyer may be roused to find and store information about the brands that reference members' use or even utilize the brand pattern to frame group inclinations. In this way, BS can be an active retail strategy that has critical ramifications for MCPBFCB.



As the fashion clothing products are directly connected to brand consumer perception, advertisers should concentrate on those brand-related cues to draw the attention of millennials. A consumer with a higher BS displays more concern of BC, BA and BN. In this way, marketers ought to improve consumers' knowledge of a fashion clothing item by dispersing important brand-related information in well-known media. With these innovations, the brand marketers can gain strong associations with the millennial consumers. To further build their status with the millennial consumers, the marketers should utilize imaginative exercises like customized data, promotions and referral projects to build the customers' BC and BA and increase the knowledge of national and international brands, which in turn will increase the millennials' advocacy and purchasing of their favorite fashion clothing brands.

## Limitations of the study and future research

The findings of this study contribute to the field of consumer research in a particular segment (i.e., millennials) as well as fashion clothing brands. However, similarly, as with any exploration, several limitations exist inside the setting of this empirical research. The principal confinement originates from the sample and extent of the investigation. Though the current sample is justified statistically, this sample may not apply to the entire population. On the other hand, if the information accumulation could cover a more extended timeframe and have a more significant sample estimate, the representativeness of the sample could be improved and the findings generalized. The impact of different factors like consumer feelings, emotions, customer service, store condition and retailer qualities were not considered in this investigation. Thus, future research may focus on these aspects as well.

The proposed model was developed to study how the millennial's purchasing behavior is being influenced by BC, BA, BN and BS. The study suggests that future research may cover the dimensions of brand experience and brand-related stimuli to understand MCPBFCB. The current study has also been limited to a particular product only (fashion clothing brands). Further research into other product categories such as luxury products, destination tourism, or even services, would add more meaningful findings into the brand literature.

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